

Sigmund Freud PrivatUniversität Wien

CoARA Action Plan 2024-2029

Austria's largest private higher education institution, Sigmund Freud Private University (SFU) has four faculties in the disciplines Psychotherapy Science, Psychology, Medicine, and Law, at six European sites: Vienna, Linz (Austria), Berlin, Ljubljana, Milan, and Paris (SFU Organisation Chart). While the four faculties enjoy autonomy, disciplinary boundaries remain permeable, thanks to transdisciplinary research projects. The Faculties of Psychotherapy Science (PTS) and Psychology in particular bear unique disciplinary dialogues across national borders, hosting diverse research cultures.

SFU's current period of institutional change is marked by its third extension of institutional accreditation, including the revision of research strategy and major expansion of the Research Support Center (ZFS) in 2023, and its first transition of leadership in 2025. Following indirect membership to the Coalition for Advancing Research Assessment (CoARA) through the Austrian Conference of Private Universities (ÖPUK) in 2022 and contribution to the working group on "Careers in Research in the Context of the European Research Area" by Austrian University Conference (uniko) until 2024, SFU signed the Agreement of Reforming Research Assessment (ARRA) in October 2024, joining the CoARA as an independent research institution.

SFU's CoARA Action Plan is set to guide strategic leadership, administration, and quality management alongside researchers from all career levels towards a research environment that will sustainably support SFU's diverse and international research cultures. It consists of three consecutive phases: Firstly, university-wide preparations; secondly, a pilot project at the Faculty of Psychology, intensified by the Institutional Pilot Project selected during the 2nd round of the CoARA Cascade Funding ('CoARaverse in Psychology. Piloting reforms to foster and assess diverse research cultures with a focus on participation, qualitative indicators, and peer-review'); and thirdly, the adaptation of the outcomes by the remaining faculties and research institutes.

Action	Corresponding Commitments	Timeframe	Responsibilities
Preparation			
Evaluation of current research assessment structures, introduction of international and interdisciplinary participation models, revised reporting and evaluation instruments	1, 2, 10	06/2023 - 12/2023	Vice Rector Research; Vice Deans of Research; Vice Deans of International Affairs; QM
Implementation of RIS Pure	7, 10	04/2024 - 12/2025	Vice Rector Research; ZFS; Research Offices; QM
Faculties' coordination on CoARA commitments, including on FoP pilot (cf. below)	5, 7	02/2024 - 10/2024	Vice Rector Research; Vice Deans of Research; Research Office of the Faculty of Psychology (FoP); QM

Action	Corresponding Commitments	Timeframe	Responsibilities
Pilot Project within the Faculty of Psychology (FoP)			
Allocation of a Student Assistant Position to the Research Office FoP	5	09/2024 - 08/2025	Vice Dean of Research, Research Office FoP
Establishment of CoARA Core Team (CCT)	5, 7	10/2024	Vice Dean of Research FoP; Student Assistant at Research Office FoP; representative of QM
Communication about CoARA membership, intention to reform, and FoP pilot (presentation at Faculty Research Days; exchange with representatives of other faculties; news on website; research newsletter)	7	11/2024 - 09/2025	Vice Rector Research; CCT; Press Contact and Media Enquiries
Constitution of the FoP Working Group	1, 5, 7	11/2024 - 02/2025	CCT; researchers of all levels at FoP
Critical input to research quality objectives, indicators, and Pure (cf. above)	2 – 7	02/2025 - 08/2025	FoP Working Group
Application: 2 nd Call of Cascade Funding		04/2025	Vice Rector Research; CCT
Institutional Pilot Project: 'CoARaverse in Psychology. Piloting reforms to foster and assess diverse research cultures with a focus on participation, qualitative indicators, and peer review.		09/2025 - 08/2026	Vice Rector Research; CCT; FoP Working Group, further: CoARaverse working group
Reforming the annual Research Report FoP	2, 10	11/2025 - 04/2026	CCT; CoARaverse Working Group
	Milestones: Report for pilot testing CoARaverse KPIs in Pure; Assessment practices implemented, and reporting workspace developed and published via Zenodo		
Reforming the annual Development Interview (DI)	1 – 6	09/2025 - 02/2026	CCT; CoARaverse Working Group
	Milestones: Revised version of the annual DI guide, recognising “research-related care practices”		
Specification of FoP External Research	2, 4, 5	05/2026 - 08/2026	CCT; CoARaverse Working Group

Action	Corresponding Commitments	Timeframe	Responsibilities
Evaluation	Milestones: Confirmation of process description; Provision of guidelines for self-reporting		
Communication and Dissemination	7 - 9	09/2025 - 08/2026	CCT; Press Contact and Media Enquiries
	Milestones: Communication materials developed; Presentation of CoARAverse at ÖPUK; collaboration partners		
Adaptation of the Pilot Outcomes			
Piloting external research evaluation of the Faculty of Psychology	2, 4, 5	09/2026 - 08/2027	Vice Dean of Research, Research Office FoP
Establishment of CoARA working groups across SFU faculties	5 - 7		Deans and Research Offices of the faculties
Evaluation of outcomes in advance of the extension of institutional accreditation	10	08/2027	Vice Rector Research; QM
Evolving CoARA outcomes in the context of the extension of institutional accreditation	6, 10	01/2028	Vice Rector Research; Deans and Research Offices of Faculties; QM
Further outreach and networking events, possibly in cooperation with other HE and Research Institutions	7 - 9	06/2028	Vice Rector Research; Deans and Research Offices of Faculties; QM
Second cycle of evaluation of developed CoARA outcomes	6, 10	08/2029	Vice Rector Research; QM
Sharing of evaluation learnings within CoARA	7 - 9	10/2029	Vice Rector Research; QM